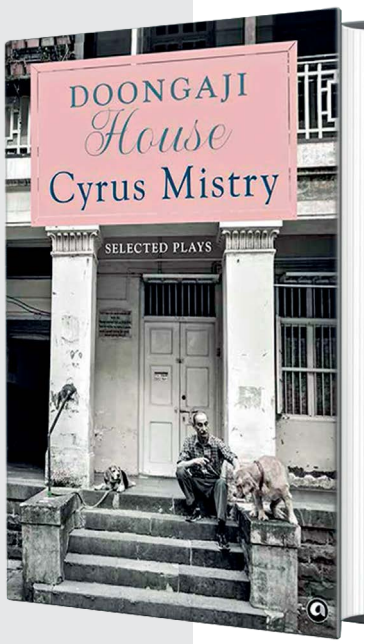
DOONGAJI HOUSE
Selected Plays
by Cyrus Mistry
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
252 pages;
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recalls Eugene O'Neill more than anyone else; that master died in 1953. In Indian drama in English, however, the genre survived, from Asif Currimbhoy to Dattani, even down to the latter's recent *Where Did I Leave My Purdah*.

I make this point before turning to the plays individually because it explains why I cannot divulge their storylines. Melodrama pivots on plot-driven crises and revelations (most evident in *Legacy*), which if described become spoilers. To compensate, I can add that Mistry creates domestic drama in realistic settings: *Doongaji* and *Flowering* located in Parsi families and *Legacy* in a Marathi Christian homestead, all in or around Mumbai.

Doongaji depicts a slice of Parsi life in an old building with several residents; the leads a sexagenarian couple concerned about their adult children. The house itself resembles another character—Mistry's detailed stage directions offer wonderful opportunities to the set and lighting designers as well as a major challenge in the final act.

Legacy reveals his strong visual sense of scenography and lights again as it tells the story of a brother and sister in their fifties living with the next generation in a country house, the centre of property wrangling and adultery. In both plays, Mistry's old-fashioned exposition to provide the background in the opening scenes reminds me of Ibsen, too obvious a craft nowadays for credible dialogue.

Flowering returns to a Parsi abode where a foul-mouthed father and anxious mother worry about their daughter, who has suffered a breakdown and left her husband. As if recognising the obsolescence of melodrama, Mistry uses the word deprecatingly in two speeches, drops any such devices from the plot, and adopts a muted development instead. But some superfluous scenes digress, like those of a faith healer and the neighbour in hospital, whereas the neighbour's life-affirming role becomes ultimately so significant that he should have received deeper treatment. The weak and abrupt concluding scene demands revision.

Moving with the times, Mistry freely mixes Gujarati and Hindi, making it effectively trilingual. However, this necessitates translation of these lines in English so that non-Gujarati/ Hindi readers and directors can follow—likewise for the earlier plays, where brief glossaries can suffice for the fewer such words. Aleph's editing, unfortunately, is imperfect, but that is the sad norm in publishing today. ■

–Ananda Lal

bribes him; an American hunter, Carnegie King: "He had the peculiar blocky solidity that some Americans have, as if they've been carved whole from an old oak"; quintessential opportunist Gangu Ram: "If you shake any tree in a fifty-mile radius, a Gangu Ram or two will fall from it"; Arun, who is hammered into a Deng Xiaoping lookalike; small-time gangster from D.A.V. college, Haggu Bumwaala; and "The Analysts" from Railway School led by Tharki: "India is a nation of analysts. One man will do the job and a hundred will stand around him, analysing", whose father "was famously the greatest lecher State Bank of India has ever seen, either in the City Branch or in the one on Bank Road".

Ahmad gets the provincial details right: Hara jeans from Nepal, the AH Wheeler bookshop, Capstan cigarettes, "dunlop rotis", the "grilled window of a college behind which a hidden clerk was collecting the fees". He knows his guns–and not just the *katta*, ubiquitous in these parts: "her trusty handmade Holland and Holland .500 Express rifle" and the "twelve-bore shotgun, a gun for duck or deer, not big game". He has a knack for the disarmingly fresh metaphor: "the drinking had left Chintu Saxena as soft as a Jaipuri razai".

The tight prose is

The narrator is Kallu, a raconteuring street mongrel, also known as "*kamina, harami, chor*"



marred by occasional inconsistency: too much sprinkling of pointless Hindi dust on page 23: "*Dekho, dekho*", "*Chalo*", "*Hai, hai*" and "*Lo, Kallu ashiq*". Too much obvious play on tail/ tale: "How much more difficult to straighten a dog's tales then" on the last page of the Prologue, and in the first paragraph of the opening story: "Let me begin at the tail end of it all". The background chapter on Gorakhpur reads more like a Wikipedia entry than a dog telling a story in his voice. While the author makes fun of a character's inability to pronounce "rendezvous", he himself uses "thrice"–an archaism used mainly by Indians–in the same sentence.

Ahmad sits in judgement on his characters and induces little empathy. The reader gets the sense that he is looking down on them while sending them up, which is camouflaged by harping on an exaggerated affinity to Gorakhpur's "mitti". ■

–Palash Krishna Mehrotra